un-Islamic influences, women had to cover their heads in public while alcohol, Western pop music and most Western films were banned. There were also mass trials of the Shah's former supporters and many were executed.

Khomeini and his government were keen to spread the Islamic revolution to what they saw as the corrupt, un-Islamic regimes in other parts of the Muslim world. Above all, they denounced the ties which bound other states to the West. A popular slogan was: 'Neither East nor West, but an Islamic government.'

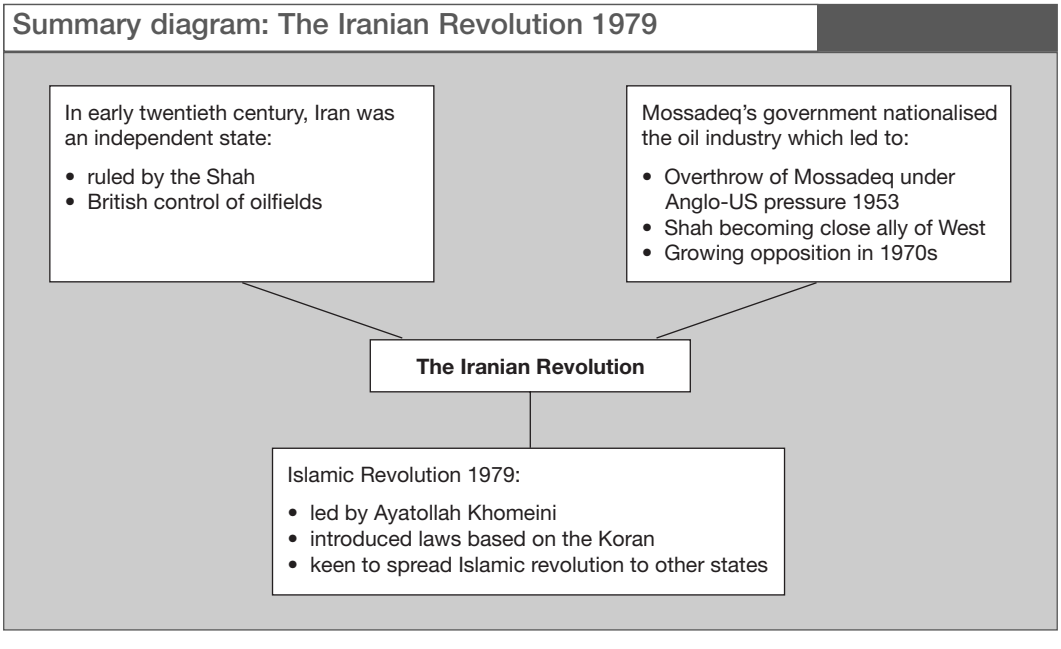
The storming of the US embassy, November 1979

The USA, the former ally of the Shah, was seen as the main enemy in Iran and came to be known as 'The Great Satan'. When the US government allowed the Shah into the USA to receive medical treatment in November 1979, militant Iranian students stormed the US embassy in Tehran, and took 50 of the American staff as hostages. The US government declared Iran to be an international 'outlaw'. Yet millions in the Muslim world, both Arab and non-Arab, admired Khomeini for standing up to the West. Khomeini also took up the cause of the Palestinians and invited Yasser Arafat to Iran, where he received a hero's welcome.

Meanwhile, neighbouring Iraq was a prime target for the export of the Islamic Revolution. It had a completely **secular** government and a growing religious opposition. It also had a large Shiite population, who were excluded from top positions in government. Khomeini accused the Iraq government of being 'atheist' and 'corrupt' and, in one of his broadcasts to the people of Iraq, he called on them to: 'Wake up and topple this corrupt regime in your Islamic country before it is too late.'

This was a direct challenge to the new President of Iraq, Saddam Hussein.

Key term

Secular
Not religious or spiritual: a secular state is one not based on religion.

Summary diagram: The Iranian Revolution 1979